A CRITICAL ANALYSIS OF ENVIRONMENTAL ACTIVISTS' VANDALISM OF ART

INTRODUCTION:

"Our government doesn't give a fuck about its responsibilities." (Just stop oil – just stop oil. Just Stop Oil – No More Oil and Gas. (2024, March 22). https://juststopoil.org/)
Environmental protection organizations raise awareness through vandalism. (Who are they) (Petras, G., & Borresen, J. (2023, May 30). From Mona Lisa to the scream: Climate protesters deface art in Europe – and now the US. USA Today. https://www.usatoday.com/in-depth/graphics/2022/11/30/climate-activists-attack-paintings-mona-lisa-scream/10699588002/) Targeting on museums and galleries. (Kinyon, L., Dolšak, N. & Prakash, A. When, where, and which climate activists have vandalized museums. npj Clim. Action 2, 27 (2023). https://doi.org/10.1038/s44168-023-00054-5) (Show the data: how many art works/who are they/ where)(Petras, G., & Borresen, J. (2023, May 30). From Mona Lisa to the scream: Climate protesters deface art in Europe – and now the US. USA Today. https://www.usatoday.com/in-depth/graphics/2022/11/30/climate-activists-attack-paintings-mona-lisa-scream/10699588002/)
A German activist yelled "When will you finally start to listen?" after daubing Monet with puree. (Nayeri, F. (2022, November 2). There is a long history of vandalizing art for a cause. but is it effective?. Artnet News. https://news.artnet.com/art-world-archives/vandals-with-a-cause-op-ed-2203145)
Vandalizing art--> Effective?

WHY ART?:

1. What do art works represent?
Historically:

a. French revolution:
- MY friend," wrote Diderot in 1765, "if we love truth more than the fine arts, let us pray God for some iconoclasts."
- "symbols of royalty, superstition and ignorance," or of "slavery, despotism and fanaticism" (Idzerda, S. J. (1954). Iconoclasm during the French Revolution. The American Historical Review, 60(1), 13–26. https://doi.org/10.2307/1842743)

b. Chinese cultural revolution(Kraus, R. C. (2012). The Cultural Revolution: a very short introduction. Oxford University Press.)

Inevitable malady of human development? People destroy paintings and sculptures, damaging them... People have always been responding to paintings and sculptures in these ways; they continue to do so today. (Gamboni, D. (1997). The destruction of art: iconoclasm and vandalism since the French Revolution. Reaktion books.)

NOW: Environmental activist similar: they **are destroying not the artworks themselves**, but

rather the **investments, preservation efforts, and attention that surround them,** which they think the environment doesn't have. In this case, their action can be classified as ideological vandalism. (Zimbardo, P. G. (1970). A Social-Psychological Analysis of Vandalism: Making Sense out of Senseless Violence. https://doi.org/10.21236/ad0719405) "What is worth more? Art or life?" (NBCUniversal News Group. (2022, October 29). Why climate change activists vandalizing art is so powerful. MSNBC. https://www.msnbc.com/opinion/msnbc-opinion/why-climate-change-activists-vandalizing-art-so-powerful-n1300371) Similar to the era of the French Revolution when revolutionaries perceived art's significance as antagonistic to truth, environmental activists think life is more important than art. "Libraries do not produce food; cannot fuel cars, tanks, or airplanes; nor do they as a rule represent a value that can be readily deposited into foreign bank accounts. So why not just ignore them?"(Garrett, J. (2009). Why Burn a Library? [Review of Books on Fire: The Destruction of Libraries throughout History; Burning Books and Leveling Libraries: Extremist Violence and Cultural Destruction; A Universal History of the Destruction of Books: From Ancient Sumer to Modern Iraq, by L. X. Polastron, J. E. Graham, R. Knuth, F. Báez, & A. MacAdam]. The Library Quarterly: Information, Community, Policy, 79(4), 489–493. https://doi.org/10.1086/605386) Art is similar. Artists infect people with spiritual energy, not with some inevitable rational arguments.(Tarkovsky, A. (1986). Andrey Tarkovsky: Sculpting in time: Reflections on the cinema. Bodley Head.) "The arts are not a way to make a living." (Vonnegut, K., & Simon, D. (2014). A man without a country. Bloomsbury Publishing.) According to them, art indeed cannot achieve substantial satisfaction. According to Maslow's hierarchy of needs, art belongs to self-actualization, the highest need. (McLeod, S. (2007). Maslow's hierarchy of needs. Simply psychology, 1(1-18).) For environment activists, the psychological needs and safety needs of human existence are under threat. Climate activists throw mashed potatoes at Monet painting: "People are starving, people are freezing, people are dying." (NBCUniversal News Group. (2022, October 29). Why climate change activists vandalizing art is so powerful. MSNBC. https://www.msnbc.com/opinion/msnbc-opinion/why-climate-change-activists-vandalizing-art-so-powerful-n1300371) Our families, our children, may face hunger in the future as a result of the devastation of the natural environment. (YouTube. (2022a, October 23). Patrick Bet-David sits down with the "just stop oil" activists who threw soup on Van Gogh's painting. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BXNcaCxqbLQ&t=173s)

So they think the environment protection deserves to have more attention than art works have, since it is also a way of protecting human's basic needs. Vandalizing art is parallel to the action of destroying nature. And they utilize the attention towards art to raise awareness about environmental issues because they are vandalizing the most valuable ones.(Cordess, C., & Turcan, M. (1993). ART VANDALISM. The British Journal of Criminology, 33(1), 95–102. http://www.jstor.org/stable/23637744)

RESULTS ACHIEVED:
(Negative)
1. ECOTERRORISM:

Their actions have earned them a name: 'ecoterrorism'. (media in different nations)(Brown, C. S. (2007). Beyond Intrinsic Value: Undermining the Justification of Ecoterrorism. The American Journal of Economics and Sociology, 66(1), 113–126. http://www.jstor.org/stable/27739623) Countries define extremist protection organizations as terrorism to avoid potential radicalism. (Spadaro, P. A. (2020). Climate Change, Environmental Terrorism, Eco-Terrorism and Emerging Threats. Journal of Strategic Security, 13(4), 58 – 80. https://www.jstor.org/stable/26965518) which means they consider their actions as dangerous and destructive.

Opposite Impact: Lose supports?

Destroying valuable artworks can result in a "boomerang effect," pushing others further away from the perpetrator, as they only attract those who share their mindset. (Teixeira da Silva, J. A. (2023). Is the destruction of art a desirable form of climate activism? Environmental Smoke, 6(1), 73–77. https://doi.org/10.32435/envsmoke.20236173-77) Because vandalizing art works is blasphemy against the creator, for art holds value, whether it be material or spiritual.(Cordess, C., & Turcan, M. (1993). ART VANDALISM. The British Journal of Criminology, 33(1), 95–102. http://www.jstor.org/stable/23637744)Restoring and cleaning art takes money and manpower(Roos, H.-E. (1992). Vandalism as a Symbolic Act in Free Zones. In C. Harriet H., J. Darryll J., & B. Martha H.)Also disturbing tourists(Guardian News and Media. (2024, February 6). After 38 attacks on art, climate protesters have fallen into Big Oil's trap – it's time to change tack | Giovanni Aloi. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/artanddesign/2024/feb/06/after-38-attacks-on-art-climate-protesters-have-fallen-into-big-oils-trap-its-time-to-change-tack) --> an outrageous act of vandalism

Arrested:
(CBS Interactive. (2024, January 29). 2 climate activists arrested after throwing soup at "Mona lisa" in Paris. CBS News. https://www.cbsnews.com/news/climate-activists-throw-soup-mona-lisa-louvre-paris-france/)

(Climate protester vandalizes wall at National Gallery, officials ... (n.d.). https://www.washingtonpost.com/dc-md-va/2023/11/14/national-gallery-protester-vandalize-art-arrested/)

(Guardian News and Media. (2023a, November 6). Just stop oil protesters smash glass on painting at National Gallery. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/uk-news/2023/nov/06/just-stop-oil-protesters-smash-glass-painting-national-gallery)

(Positive)

2. HIGH EXPOSURE

1) Sunflowers: news watched 1.29 million views 2022(YouTube. (2022a, October 14). Climate protesters throw soup on Van Gogh painting. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BN-C5N60u_M .)being interviewed on TV programs(GB

News)230,000 people watched 2023(YouTube. (2023, March 27). Just stop oil's Phoebe Plummer argues "people are dying" in net zero clash with Jacob Rees-Mogg. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8AbAurKzI48&t=91s)

2) The Scream: 2.17 million views 2022(YouTube. (2022d, November 15). Museum staff stops climate protest at "the scream" painting. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-Z26ldhlpOo&t=17s)
都需要加上具体的 Date

3) Mona Lisa: 2024 380,000 views (YouTube. (2024, January 28). Activists deface Leonardo da Vinci's Mona Lisa in Paris | DW news. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8hANE6qCldo)

These are what they want since they didn't aim to attack art themselves but raise awareness. "This demonstration was clearly an act of expression aimed to raise public awareness of the greatest threat humanity has ever faced, and NOT an endeavour intended to damage private property, nor a reckless, unconsidered act of vandalism."
(Hay wain pair walk free after judge rejects custodial sentence – just stop oil. Just Stop Oil – No More Oil and Gas. (2022, December 6). https://juststopoil.org/2022/12/06/courts-update-6-december/)

"There have been messages of hay of course and there have been messages of support as well because people realize that this is a proportionate act to a criminal government. The government's in action is **Criminal**. I'm **not a criminal I'm a scared little kid trying to fight for their future.**"
Phoebe Plummer
(YouTube. (2022, November 3). The protester who threw soup on a Van Gogh. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j_fiNoOWLm8)

MORAL COURAGE?
The individual in the follower role will need moral courage both to disobey unethical, illegal, and immoral orders.(Thomas, T., & Chaleff, I. (2017). Moral courage and intelligent disobedience. InterAgency Journal, 8(1), 58-66.)**(Stimulus material 1)(Still need 1)**

They took what they deemed moral actions: no longer remaining silent, bravely protesting despite the risk of potential arrest. Ron Arnold, executive vice-president of the Center for the Defense of Free Enterprise (CDFE), claims to have coined the term in a 1983 article in the libertarian monthly Reason, defining it as "a crime committed to save nature." (Hirsch-Hoefler, S., & Mudde, C. (2014). "Ecoterrorism": Terrorist Threat or Political Ploy? Studies in Conflict & Terrorism, 37(7), 586–603. https://doi.org/10.1080/1057610X.2014.913121)

Maybe can be compared with the women's civil Rights Movement in the United States in the early 20th century. According to Emmeline Pankhurst(Freedom or Death - Nov. 13, 1913
Emmeline Pankhurst

November 13, 1913— Hartford, Connecticut)People asked: "How are they going to persuade people that they ought to have the vote by breaking their windows?" And she replied that this was what they have to do -->the only way.

Environmental activists even protest in a relatively tender way: they didn't cause potential physical harms to human. (Cordess, C., & Turcan, M. (1993). ART VANDALISM. The British Journal of Criminology, 33(1), 95–102. http://www.jstor.org/stable/23637744)Just stop oil defined themselves as non-violent forces. (Just stop oil – just stop oil. Just Stop Oil – No More Oil and Gas. (2024, March 22). https://juststopoil.org/)

CONCLUSION:

Not really effective, since the governments didn't respond to their acts by taking actual actions rather than criticizing them because their goals are unpractical in nowadays society. According to Just Stop Oil activists, their goal-->Stop oil energy and use renewable energy sources entirely.(YouTube. (2022a, October 14). Climate protesters throw soup on Van Gogh painting. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BN-C5N60u_M .) However, even though renewable energies offer significant potentials, they cannot fully replace oil energy due to many factors like engineering feasibility, reliability, applicability, economy, scarcity of supply, and public acceptance.(Dincer, I. (2000). Renewable energy and sustainable development: a crucial review. Renewable and sustainable energy reviews, 4(2), 157-175.)They not only create chaos, vandalize valuable art pieces, and also ignore the feasibility of their plan. Not moral courage, but rather reckless and ignorant.